# 3. A PIECE OF STRING (GUY DE MAUPASSANT)

The story unfolds on a busy market day in the French town of Goderville, where peasant farmers and local townspeople gather to buy, sell, and manage their agricultural business. Among them is Maitre Hauchecorne, an economical and thrifty old peasant from Breaute who suffers from painful rheumatism. While walking through the market square, Hauchecorne notices a small, worthless piece of string lying on the cobblestone ground. Believing that everything useful should be saved, he painfully bends down to pick it up and begins carefully rolling it up to store in his pocket. However, as he does so, he notices his bitter rival, Maitre Malandain the harness-maker, watching him intently from the doorway of his shop. Embarrassed at being seen by his enemy picking up something so petty, Hauchecorne quickly hides the string in his trousers and pretends to continue searching the ground for something valuable before walking away.

Later that afternoon, while Hauchecorne is eating at a local inn, the town crier announces that a leather pocketbook containing five hundred francs and important business papers was lost earlier that morning on the public road. Shortly after, a police officer arrives and summons Hauchecorne to the Mayor's office. When Hauchecorne arrives, the Mayor formally accuses him of stealing the lost pocketbook. The accusation is based entirely on the testimony of Malandain, who claims he saw Hauchecorne picking up the lost item from the road at the exact time it disappeared. Stunned and horrified, Hauchecorne vehemently protests his innocence, repeatedly pulling the small piece of string out of his pocket to prove his story. However, the Mayor refuses to believe him, arguing that a man of Malandain's standing would not mistake a string for a pocketbook. Hauchecorne is searched completely, but no money is found, and he is eventually allowed to leave with a warning.

The following day, a farm laborer named Marius Paumelle finds the pocketbook on the road and returns it intact along with all its contents to its rightful owner, Maitre Houlbreque. Overjoyed and relieved, Hauchecorne returns to the market, fully expecting the townspeople to acknowledge his innocence and apologize for suspecting him. Instead, the local villagers mock him relentlessly and refuse to believe his story. They assume that Hauchecorne stole the money initially and then arranged for an accomplice to "find" and return it once the police became involved. The more Hauchecorne tries to explain the truth and defend his personal honor, the more the community laughs at him, calling him a cunning old rascal.

Deeply wounded by the total destruction of his reputation and integrity, Hauchecorne becomes completely obsessed with clearing his name. He wanders through the town telling his story about the piece of string to every stranger and neighbor he encounters, but his growing desperation only makes him a figure of ridicule throughout the region. The relentless stress, public humiliation, and social rejection take a severe toll on his physical and mental health. He falls dangerously ill and is confined to his bed. Even in his final moments of delirium on his deathbed, his mind remains trapped by the unjust accusation, and he dies repeating his last desperate words: "A piece of string, a piece of string—look, here it is, Mr. Mayor!"